

Product Requirements Document: Better Specialty Coffee

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1. Project Vision and Strategic Objectives

The “Better Specialty Coffee” platform is conceived as a digital sanctuary for the modern coffee enthusiast, bridging the gap between high-end e-commerce and the immersive atmosphere of a physical specialty cafe. The primary vision is to create a “slow bar” digital experience that prioritizes quality, transparency, and a unique “Coffee till I Die” aesthetic. By focusing on the elite tier of coffee—specifically lots scoring 80 or higher on the Specialty Coffee Association (SCA) scale—the platform aims to establish itself as the definitive destination for discerning brewers who value the craft behind every bean.

The strategic goals of this project extend beyond simple transactions. We aim to elevate the craft by providing radical transparency into the supply chain, from the specific altitude of the farm to the intricate processing methods used by the farmers. Furthermore, the platform is designed to foster long-term loyalty through the “Coffee Concierge” service, a personalized subscription model that adapts to individual consumption habits. This document outlines the functional, technical, and design requirements necessary to realize this vision, ensuring a high-performance, mobile-first experience that resonates with a dark, edgy brand identity.

2. Philosophy and Core Values

The foundation of “Better Specialty Coffee” rests on four pillars that guide every product decision and design choice. These values ensure that the platform remains true to the specialty coffee culture while pushing the boundaries of traditional e-commerce.

Core Value	Strategic Definition	Practical Application
Quality over Quantity	A commitment to the SCA 80+ standard, ensuring only the finest lots are featured.	Curated product selection with no “filler” items; emphasis on unique flavor profiles and limited batches.
Radical Transparency	Providing users with comprehensive data about the origin and journey of their coffee.	Detailed farmer profiles, altitude specifications, and processing method breakdowns on every product page.
Swiss Minimalism	A design philosophy focused on clarity, perfect typography, and the removal of visual clutter.	High-contrast layouts, generous white space, and a focus on high-quality photography over decorative elements.
Edgy Sophistication	A dark, “Coffee till I Die” aesthetic that differentiates the brand from “clean” competitors.	Use of pure black backgrounds, bone-white typography, and stylized skeleton brand mascots.

3. Functional Requirements and User Experience

3.1 The Bean Matrix: Advanced Product Discovery

The centerpiece of the e-commerce experience is “The Bean Matrix,” a sophisticated filtering and discovery system. Unlike traditional stores that categorize by region alone, this matrix allows users to navigate the catalog through complex sensory attributes. Users can filter by specific flavor notes—such as fruity, chocolatey, or floral—as well as roast levels and processing methods like anaerobic fermentation or honey processing. This level of granularity ensures that enthusiasts can find the exact profile they desire, while newcomers are educated on the nuances of specialty coffee.

3.2 Integrated Brewing Intelligence

To bridge the gap between purchase and consumption, the platform integrates dynamic brewing guides directly into the user journey. These guides are not static blog posts but interactive modules tailored to specific methods such as the V60, Aeropress, or Espresso. Each guide features auto-calculating water-to-coffee ratios based on the user's desired output, ensuring a perfect brew every time. Furthermore, the system employs contextual upselling by suggesting specific filters, grinders, or kettles that are optimized for the selected bean's flavor profile and recommended brewing method.

3.3 The Coffee Concierge: Subscription Logic

The "Coffee Concierge" is a premium subscription service designed for the daily drinker. It offers a recurring delivery model with customizable frequencies, ranging from weekly to monthly intervals. The logic behind the concierge service allows users to choose between a "Rotational" plan, which introduces them to new seasonal lots, or a "Fixed Profile" plan for those who have found their perfect daily driver. A dedicated subscriber portal provides seamless control, allowing users to skip, pause, or modify their deliveries with a single click, thereby reducing friction and increasing retention.

3.4 Operational Transparency and Urgency

Real-time data is utilized to build trust and create a sense of exclusivity. Every product listing prominently displays the "Roasted On" date, ensuring that customers receive their beans at peak freshness. Additionally, for micro-lots and rare releases, the platform implements limited-batch countdowns. This transparency regarding stock levels and roast dates reinforces the "Quality over Quantity" philosophy and encourages timely purchasing decisions without resorting to traditional, high-pressure sales tactics.

4. Technical Architecture and Performance

The technical stack is selected to support a media-heavy, high-performance storefront that remains resilient under high traffic. By utilizing a headless architecture, we

decouple the presentation layer from the e-commerce engine, allowing for maximum design flexibility and near-instant load times.

Component	Technology	Rationale
Frontend Framework	Next.js (App Router)	Enables Server Components for optimized performance and SEO; provides a seamless, app-like feel.
Styling Engine	Tailwind CSS	Facilitates a utility-first approach to design, ensuring consistency across the “Swiss Minimalist” UI.
E-commerce Engine	Shopify Headless	Leverages the Storefront API for robust inventory, secure checkout, and global payment support.
Content Management	Sanity.io	Provides a flexible environment for managing rich media, brewing guides, and farmer narratives.
Deployment & Edge	Vercel	Optimized for Next.js; ensures low-latency delivery of high-quality photography globally.

5. Design Identity: “Coffee till I Die”

5.1 Visual Language and Color Theory

The visual identity of “Better Specialty Coffee” is a deliberate departure from the bright, airy aesthetics common in the industry. It adopts a “Swiss-inspired minimalism” that is high-contrast and edgy. The primary palette is anchored by a deep black (#000000) base, complemented by bone-white (#FFFFFF) typography. Accents of Forest Green and Dark Coffee Brown are used sparingly to highlight key actions and natural elements. Typography is bold and deliberate, utilizing high-contrast sans-serif faces for headings to maintain a modern, architectural feel.

5.2 Brand Mascot and Illustrative Style

To inject personality into the dark aesthetic, the brand features stylized skeleton illustrations as mascots. These “Barista Skeletons” are depicted in various stages of the coffee ritual—expertly pouring a V60 or checking the color of a roast with bony hands.

The logo, a centralized skull, can be enhanced with a subtle neon green glow or a textured bone effect to create a memorable centerpiece. These illustrations serve to humanize the brand while reinforcing the “Coffee till I Die” underground vibe.

5.3 Micro-interactions and the “Slow Bar” Feel

User interactions are designed to mimic the “slow bar” experience—deliberate, smooth, and high-quality. Subtle transitions guide the user through the site, avoiding jarring movements. Hover states on product cards may trigger a faint “smoke” or “steam” animation, and loading states feature a minimalist skeleton hand stirring a cup. These micro-interactions are not merely decorative; they are engineered to make the digital experience feel as premium and considered as the coffee itself.

6. Success Metrics and Roadmap

6.1 Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)

The success of the platform will be measured through a combination of commercial and performance-based metrics. We aim for a conversion rate exceeding 3.5%, driven by the optimized 3-step checkout and high-fidelity product presentation. The “Coffee Concierge” model is expected to account for 25% of total sales within the first year. From a technical perspective, maintaining a Largest Contentful Paint (LCP) of under 1.5 seconds is critical to preserving the premium feel of the site.

6.2 Development Roadmap

The project will be executed in two primary phases. Phase 1 (MVP) focuses on the foundation: the core Bean Matrix, Shopify integration, and the primary skeleton branding. Phase 2 (The Experience) will introduce more advanced features such as interactive radar charts for flavor profiling, dynamic brewing calculators, and “The Bone Club” loyalty program. This phased approach ensures a rapid time-to-market while allowing for iterative improvements based on real-world user feedback.